

Introduction:

With a polarized political landscape and an abundance of media consumed online, state leaders have repeatedly said they want to ensure Delaware's youth are informed citizens and are digitally literate to understand how to decode real and false information (Rutz 2023). In recent years the state of Delaware has made a move to put an emphasis on Civic Education classes through social studies teachings. In 2023, the State Board of Education voted on creating the Social Studies Student Assessment Performance Levels to evaluate student understanding and application of the Delaware Content Standards. The state does not only emphasize the importance of understanding civic education only through standardized tests and scores though, as they also have statewide competitions and projects where students can showcase their learning, and they're incentivized through a prize. In 2026, The University of Delaware's Center for Civics Education partnered with the U.S. Chamber of Commerce Foundation to host a nonpartisan civics competition that encourages young Americans to engage in civics and contribute to their communities. Participating 6th, 7th and 8th graders will flex their civics knowledge for a chance to win recognition and cash prizes (University of Delaware). Civic Education is vital as informed and active community members, especially our youth K-12, is what empowers others to learn and be active participants in our democracy. This participation in civics contributes to a sense of belonging and community involvement amongst the youth generation and promotes the awareness of civic issues. By becoming more informed and engaged members of our communities, we can become a more inclusive society.

Nathan Moser is a social studies teacher at the Freire Charter School of Wilmington, Delaware. Some teachers, like Moser, may feel doubt about going against the standard format of teaching a lesson and giving a test. But having that interactive learning experience is what gives

students more of an investment in their community than they'd get from a textbook. Moser is an example of a teacher who is making a positive change for his social studies class as his students are not afraid to voice their opinions on pressing issues like minimum wage, student debt or climate change. More than 90% of students at this school are students of color and he understands that a way to help this marginalized community feel empowered and interact isn't necessarily around a standard curriculum and tests. Students participate in different interactive lessons throughout the school year, like roleplaying different forms of government, tracking the stock market with fake money and looking at how to pay rent and split bills with their classmates acting as roommates, among other activities. He designs his course in a way that does not focus on standardized testing, but on valuable lessons that these teenagers of color can take with them for the future (Merola 2024). When empowering people to learn and engage in Civic Education, we must include everyone and implement methods that will make our marginalized communities also feel empowered and not afraid to voice their opinions.

DE Policy, Standards, and LEA implementation

In current Delaware State Civic standards, classes are based off of four anchors; Government, Politics, Citizenship, and Participation. For the first anchor, government, Students will examine the structure and purposes of governments with specific emphasis on constitutional democracy. K-5 will emphasize how governments have a variety of structures and exist for many purposes explained in the United States and State constitutions. They will also understand how the people elect officials, and the three branches of powers and their responsibilities. Grades 6-12 will explain why governments have the authority to enforce laws, and the different functions between state, local, and federal government. Different values, cultures and ideologies around the world will also be taught.

For the second civics anchor standard, politics, students will understand the principles and ideals underlying the American political system. In grades K-12 the standards state that students will learn The American political system and how it was intentionally created to rest on a foundation of individual liberty, freedom of religion, representative democracy, equal opportunity, and equal protection under the law. These principles and ideals are codified in the United States Constitution, the Bill of Rights, and other significant documents. Understanding, achieving, and upholding them represents a major challenge to each succeeding generation of American citizens.

For the third civics anchor standard, citizenship, students will understand the responsibilities, rights, and privileges of United States citizens. These standards state that the political, religious, and economic freedoms provided to American citizens are accompanied by the responsibility of active civic participation at the individual, community, state, and national levels. Effective citizens need to understand the dedication and commitment necessary to safeguard those rights for themselves and future generations, as well as the potential consequences of inaction. They should also be able to distinguish between rights and privileges. The fourth and final civics anchor standard is participation. With this anchor, students will develop and employ the civic skills necessary for effective, participatory citizenship. The intent to participate in the American political system must be matched with the specific skills necessary to be effective. Such skills include but are not limited to registering to vote; interacting successfully with government agencies; organizing and working in civic groups; researching and advocating a position; or serving in an office of public trust.

The LEA implementation for the Delaware Department of Education is guidance and planning to address student achievement that is tailored to LEA-specific needs and DDOE

priorities. All strategies/activities in this LEA plan address root causes of the District's urgent performance trends. These activities include increasing the scale of strategies that have demonstrated success; addressing systemic root causes of low performance; building institutional knowledge and leadership capacity; and addressing low performance subgroups and schools. This plan also emphasizes how resources are focused on a limited number of prioritized strategies that can be implemented with quality during the specified duration. Also, action steps articulate clear and specific commitments and deliverables as concrete verifiable products. All activities have a single owner who is ultimately responsible for implementation and federal funding sources are included with specific amounts. All together, these characteristics analyze student data, root causes, and strategies most likely to remediate performance issues. Traditional funding sources are also innovated to be able to implement these strategies.

Youth Civic Engagement Data:

In Delaware, a higher participation of youth civic engagement through voting is missing. For the 2022 election the voter turnout was 18.2%, lower than the national average of 23%. 25,190 votes were cast out of the 83,629 youth citizen population. Despite the rates of low voter turnouts in Delaware amongst the youth, there are higher rates of youth civic engagement in certain categories. They are on par with national average, as 65% of people aged 16-29 stated that they discussed political/social issues with friends and family. 76.9% of young people had a conversation or spent time with a neighbor of a different culture/ethnic background of their own, compared to the national rate of 53%. 35.1% of youth stated that they shared their own views about news/politics on their social media compared to the national rate of 26.1% (CIRCLE). Despite youth in Delaware having higher rates of civic engagement talks and interactions than the national average, there were low voter turnouts. Not only that, but discussing political/social

issues with family and friends is still a controversial topic as only 65% of young people do this. It is crucial for this 65% to be higher, because usually this is one of the first steps in civic engagement. It allows us to think critically and understand real world issues. This strengthens democratic habits and encourages engagement in civic life. Hearing perspectives and opinions from others can also counteract misinformation that we may hear about in the media. More conversations about political and social issues amongst friends and family is what is missing too. Hearing how policies can affect people, especially minorities, can motivate people into volunteering, voting, or even advocacy.

Marginalized groups in Civic Engagement:

In Delaware, these policies and standards have attempted to make civic education more inclusive but not all minority groups are consistently well served. Immigrant and mixed-status families face fear around legal status and are limited when it comes to citizenship and participation which are the third and fourth anchors of civic education in the state. They have less access to civic participation opportunities, and some children in these families are unable to participate in what is taught at school. For black and brown youth and Hispanic communities, civic engagement opportunities may differ by community with these groups having less access and resources to civic engagement especially where students of color comprise most of the population and are given less resources. Disabled students might be included physically in civic engagement opportunities, but activities such as debates, discussions, mock trials, and simulations are not always adapted well for someone who might be blind or hearing impaired. For LGBTQIA youth there are resources in Delaware schools, but implementation also depends on teachers and social/political climates can affect whether or not these individuals feel included or excluded. Even though Delaware recognizes diversity and attempts to include marginalized

voices, not all marginalized groups are consistently served well. There needs to be changes so that everyone can feel included and feel empowered to participate in Civics despite their status, physical appearance, impairment, and/or identity.

Works Cited

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